

1977 General Zia assumes the presidency. Islam is adopted as the first principle of the constitution.

1979 Martial law lifted following victory of Zia's Bangladesh National Party (BNP) in elections.

1981 General Zia is assassinated in failed military coup. Succeeded by Abdus Sattar.

1982 General Ershad takes over in coup.

1983 Ershad assumes the presidency, an act confirmed in a referendum in 1985.

1986 Awami League (AL) and BNP fail to unseat Ershad in elections.

1987 Ershad announces state of emergency after opposition demonstrations and strikes.

1988 Islam becomes the constitutional state religion. Floods cover three-quarters of country. Opposition boycotts elections.

1990 Ershad resigns following mass demonstrations.

1991 Elections won by BNP. Khaleda Zia becomes prime minister. Ershad is imprisoned for corruption. The role of the president is reduced to ceremonial functions. Cyclonic floods kill 150,000.

1994 Author Taslima Nasreen, accused of blasphemy, flees to Sweden.

1996 General election, boycotted by opposition parties, returns BNP to power. Opposition parties reject result and force fresh elections. Sheikh Hasina Wajed of the AL takes power.

1997 Ershad is released from prison. Opposition begins campaign of strikes against the government.

1998 Two-thirds of country devastated by worst-ever floods. Fifteen former army officers are sentenced to death for involvement in assassination of President Mujib in 1975.

2000 In a row with Pakistan over the 1971 war, Bangladesh demands an apology for alleged genocide.

2001 Elections won by BNP. Supreme Court declares the issuing of religious decrees (fatwas) to be a criminal offense. Awami League leader Hasina steps down, becoming first prime minister to complete a five-year term. Khaleda Zia's BNP wins at polls.

2002 President Musharraf of Pakistan visits Bangladesh and expresses regret for Pakistani excesses during the 1971 war. Five hundred people are killed when a ferry sinks in a storm.

2004 Opposition calls 21 general strikes in a campaign to oust the government. Constitution is amended to reserve 45 seats for female MPs. Bomb attacks by Islamic extremists continue. Floods in Dhaka are the worst in decades.

2005 More than 140 people are killed when a ferry capsizes in Dhaka; months later 150 are killed in a week in three ferry accidents; more than 600 died in similar ferry disasters in 2002 and 2003. Islamic extremist bombing campaign continues.

2006 AL ends year-long parliamentary boycott. Amid violent antigovernment demonstrations, President Ahmed assumes caretaker role as prime minister Zia completes her term and steps down.

2007 State of emergency declared during violence prior to election. Six Islamic extremists convicted of bombings in 2005 are hanged. Sheikh Hasina is charged with conspiring to murder a political rival; Khaleda Zia is put under house arrest.

2007 Cyclone Sidr hits Bangladesh, killing thousands of people.

2008 After more than a year of military rule, elections are held. Sheikh Hasina's Awami League wins a landslide victory.

«410–11 The Partition of India

Burma



A former British colony ruled since 1962 by the military, who renamed it Myanmar in 1989.

1000s Burma is first united under King Anarutha (1044–77), the founder of the Pagan dynasty.

1287 Burma is overrun by the forces of Kublai Khan.

1535–45 Burma is reunited under King Tabinshweti, founder of Toungoo dynasty.

1714–60 Under Alaungpaya, founder of the Kondaung dynasty, the Burmese kingdom is at its height, stretching as far as parts of Thailand and India.

1824–86 Burma fights three separate wars against the British over the boundaries of Britain's Indian Empire.

1886 Burma becomes a province of British India.

1930–31 Economic depression triggers popular unrest.

1937 Separated from India as a British crown colony.

1942 Japan invades.

1945 Anti-Fascist People's Freedom League (AFPFL), led by Aung San, helps the Allies reoccupy country.

1947 Burmese independence. Aung San wins elections, but is assassinated.

1948 Independence under new prime minister, U Nu, who initiates socialist policies. Revolts by ethnic separatists, notably the Karen liberation struggle.



Royal opulence

The Kanbawzathari palace in the ancient Burmese capital of Hanthawaddy is a testimony to the wealth of King Bayinnaung of the Toungoo dynasty (reigned 1551–81). He unified the country and conquered the Shan states and Siam (now Thailand). The king was a prolific builder and a patron of the arts.

1958 Ruling AFPFL splits into two.

1960 U Nu's faction wins elections.

1962 General Ne Win stages military coup. "New Order" policy of "Buddhist Socialism" deepens Burma's international isolation. Mining and other industries nationalized. Free trade prohibited.

1964 Socialist Program Party declared sole legal party.

1976 Ethnic liberation groups gain control of 40 percent of country.

1982 Nonindigenous people barred from public office.

1988 Thousands die in student riots. Ne Win resigns. Martial law declared. Aung San Suu Kyi, daughter of General Aung San, and others form National League for Democracy (NLD). General Saw Maung leads military coup. State Law and Order Restoration Council (SLORC) takes power.

1989 Army arrests NLD leaders. Country officially renamed Union of Myanmar.

1990 Elections permitted. NLD wins landslide but SLORC refuses to concede power. More NLD leaders arrested.

1991 Aung San Suu Kyi is awarded Nobel Peace Prize.

1992 General Than Shwe takes over as SLORC leader.

1995 Aung San Suu Kyi is released.

1997 Ruling SLORC renamed State Peace and Development Council (SPDC). US imposes sanctions and bans further investment in Burma.

1998 NLD sets deadline for convening parliament; military junta refuses.

1999 Aung San Suu Kyi rejects conditions set by SPDC for visiting the UK to see her husband, Michael Aris, who dies of cancer.

2000 Secret talks begin between Aung San Suu Kyi and SPDC. Aung San Suu Kyi under house arrest again.

2003 Aung San Suu Kyi taken into "protective custody" following clashes between her supporters and the government. Khin Nyunt becomes prime minister. He is ousted in 2004.

2007 Nationwide protests break out led by Buddhist monks, but mass arrests put them to an end.

2008 New constitution allocates a quarter of seats in parliament to the military. Cyclone Nargis kills over 100,000 people.

2009 Aung San Suu Kyi is sentenced to a further 18 months house arrest.

2010 The government-backed United Solidarity and Development Party (USDP) wins a landslide election victory. A week after the election, Aung San Suu Kyi is released from house arrest.

«172–73 Lost Empires
«184–85 The Silk Road

BURMESE POLITICIAN (1945–)

AUNG SAN SUU KYI

Aung San Suu Kyi, the Burmese opposition leader, began her nonviolent struggle for democracy in 1988 following the slaughter of student protesters by Burma's military authorities. Placed under long periods of house arrest she has refused the military's offer to free her if she leaves Burma. In 1990, the military ignored the 80 percent of parliamentary seats that her party (the NLD) won in that year's election.

